

MUHAMMAD IZAM BUHAN

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Creative operations and brand production leader with 17+ years of experience spanning design leadership, workflow systems and cross-functional coordination. Currently manages studio operations for QS's global creative studio, reporting to the Creative Associate Director and coordinating distributed teams across APAC, EMEA and Latin America. Combines strategic creative direction with hands-on operational discipline to solve complex workflow bottlenecks and build scalable design systems. Holds an MBA with an AI Major (CGPA 3.83) and is building formal project management credentials, with Google Project Management certification completed and Professional Scrum Master certification planned for 2026.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Design Studio Manager | 2021 – Present

QS Quacquarelli Symonds (Marketing Team)

- Manage day-to-day operations of QS's global creative studio, overseeing production pipelines, AI-assisted workflows and cross-regional coordination across 3 continents
- Direct creative strategy and execution for 13+ annual global summits and conferences
- Supported the rollout of the innovative QS World University Rankings product campaign, driving a 1,278% increase in LinkedIn interactions and a 277% surge in site traffic via LinkedIn for the Asia Rankings year-over-year
- Played a key role in a full global visual rebrand overhauling logos, typography, bespoke illustrative assets, iconography and colour palettes, delivering 29K+ social follower growth, a 20% sales boost and a 40% increase in customer interaction within 9 months
- Introduced Design Sprints into campaign briefing workflows to eliminate fragmented brand assets and systematically align B2B and B2C digital, print and social media touchpoints across LinkedIn, X, Facebook and TikTok
- Restructured, coached and mentored the global creative team, introducing specialised skill tracks that improved career progression, boosted team performance by 25% and achieved 100% core staff retention over five years
- Improved how we prepare templates and work files, reducing repetitive tasks by 25% and cutting production timelines by 30%
- Implement atomic and modular design systems across all digital and print outputs; reduced cross-regional feedback loops by 40% and improved version control through ClickUp and Agile workflows

Channel Navigator & Creative Manager | 2016 – 2021

QS Enrolment Solutions (formerly Hobsons, acquired by QS in 2017)

- Managed creative operations and end-to-end team management for the Kuala Lumpur studio including drafting job descriptions, hiring, line management and mentoring regional designers across APAC, EMEA and US markets
- Collaborated with Business Intelligence and APAC marketing to develop market analysis, web audits and insights reports for university clients
- Pulled data from Tableau and International Student Survey to inform client campaigns, including the university enrolment roadshow
- Designed and produced EDMs, including template creation, HTML build, content layout, QA and testing
- Tracked EDM sends through Work Engine (JIRA) and coordinated with cross-functional teams on web development and campaign optimisation

Creative Manager – Marketing | 2014 – 2016

Hobsons

- Managed APAC marketing operations and the creative studio, serving as regional brand guardian across eight key markets
- Developed integrated campaign strategies for product launches across digital and traditional channels
- Provided strategic creative recommendations to senior leadership and external stakeholders throughout the design lifecycle

Head of Creative | 2012 – 2014

ZALORA Malaysia (Rocket Internet GmbH)

- Established and built the creative function for Southeast Asia's leading fashion e-commerce platform during its high-growth launch phase
- Led end-to-end creative production across website campaigns, social media platforms (Facebook, Twitter, Instagram), SEO/PPC ads and print channels; optimised digital creative assets using on-site tracking data to improve retargeting, boost site traffic and drive lead generation
- Developed reusable design templates, brand asset libraries and artwork databases that improved production efficiency by 35% and accelerated campaign rollouts
- Presented creative proposals and performance analytics directly to senior executive leadership to align visual output with commercial growth metrics

Brand Consultant | 2009 – 2012

Alhaya Brandworks (Rosie & Partners)

- Led corporate identity projects from concept to execution delivering logo design, vector mapping, brand guidelines, keynote presentations and creative direction for startup brands
- Managed web design initiatives including front-end interfacing and coding support, project management and on-site brand training
- Managed permanent and contract design personnel, overseeing visual quality standards, project timelines and high-profile client event deliverables

Multimedia Graphic Designer | 2008 – 2009

ROVSKI Sdn Bhd

- Executed multimedia and graphic design collateral supporting corporate visual communications and marketing campaigns

Intern | Junior Graphic Designer | 2007 & 2008

Gansforhire Brand Solutions

- Early career roles building foundational expertise in advertising
- Assisted senior design staff in creative ideation, advertising layout preparation and print artwork execution

EDUCATION

Master of Business Administration (AI Major) | CGPA 3.83

Tun Razak Graduate School (UNIRAZAK) | Completed 2026

- Completed 11 subjects including Managerial Accounting, Financial Management, Generative AI Leadership & Strategy and AI Ethics & Policy
- Earned 9 microcredentials and completed a research project

- **Diploma in Graphic Design & Multimedia**
Limkokwing University | Completed 2007

SKILLS

Creative Leadership & Strategy: Creative Direction, Brand Strategy, Design Sprints, Team Mentorship & Hiring, Cross-Functional Collaboration, Stakeholder Management

Operations & Production: Workflow Optimisation, Agile/Scrum Leadership, Project Management, Budget Planning, Digital Asset Management (DAM)

Technical & Analytical: AI Prompt Engineering & Automation, Data Analysis, Modular & Atomic Design Systems, Front-End/UX Awareness, QA & Brand Compliance

CliftonStrengths (Gallup): Includer, Responsibility, Restorative, Context, Learner

CERTIFICATIONS & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Project & Operations Management: Foundations of Project Management (Google), Foundations of UX Design (Google), Foundations of Digital Marketing & E-commerce (Google)

AI & Data: Generative AI for Leaders (Vanderbilt), Introduction to AI (IBM), Artificial Intelligence Essentials V2 (Coursera), AI Ethics & Societal Challenges (Lund), What Is Generative AI? (LinkedIn)

Business & Strategy: Developing a Winning Marketing Strategy (Illinois), Developing Innovative Ideas for New Companies (Maryland), Basic Statistics (Amsterdam), Finance for Non-Finance Professionals (Rice), Managerial Accounting Fundamentals (UVA)

Planned: Professional Scrum Master Certification (PSM I) (2026)

TECHNICAL PROFICIENCIES

Category	Tools & Platforms
Design & Prototyping	Adobe Creative Suite, Sketch, Figma, Canva, Atomic/Modular Design Systems
AI & Automation	Claude, Gemini, DeepSeek, Perplexity, Custom GPTs, Canva Magic Design, Figma AI, Adobe Firefly, Midjourney, Prompt Engineering
Project & Workflow Management	ClickUp, Jira, Trello, Work Engine, Agile/Scrum Workflows
Data Analytics & Collaboration	Excel, Tableau, Microsoft Teams, Miro, Slack